

MARVEL STUDIOS: FRANCHISE BIBLE, VOL. 1

Internal codename: PROJECT BULLPEN

CLASSIFICATION: Eyes only. Do not use the word "universe" outside the building.

Canon lock. Everything in this document is fixed. Every chapter, headline, casting call and release date that follows has to agree with it.

1. THE STUDIO: MARVEL STUDIOS

Founded	1996 , by Avi Arad , when Marvel Films (est. 1993) was reorganized as Marvel Studios
Reborn as an independent studio	Tuesday, September 6, 2005 : a \$525 million non-recourse credit facility with Merrill Lynch , put together by David Maisel
Headquarters (2007)	9242 Beverly Blvd, Beverly Hills, on the floor above a Mercedes-Benz dealership

Why 1996 is the right year: Marvel spent the bankruptcy years (1996–1998) being offered money for its characters by every studio in town. Arad set up Marvel Studios so the company would **never sell a single film right**. Studios wanted to rent Spider-Man, the X-Men, the Fantastic Four and Blade, and Marvel turned all of them down. The 2005 Merrill Lynch deal was the payoff: **Marvel finances and owns its own movies**. The loan was secured by the film rights to ten characters and properties, which are only a small part of a library of more than 5,000 that Marvel owns outright: **Captain America, The Avengers, Nick Fury, Black Panther, Ant-Man, Cloak & Dagger, Doctor Strange, Hawkeye, Power Pack and Shang-Chi**.

1A. THE RIGHTS: MARVEL OWNS EVERYTHING (LOCKED)

- **Marvel owns 100% of its characters.** No film rights have ever been sold or licensed. That includes Spider-Man, the X-Men and every mutant, the Fantastic Four, Doctor Doom, Galactus, the Silver Surfer, Namor, Blade, Daredevil, the Punisher, Ghost Rider and everyone else.
- **There are no earlier Marvel theatrical films.** No *Blade* (1998), *X-Men* (2000), *Spider-Man* (2002), *Daredevil* (2003), *Hulk* (2003) or *Fantastic Four* (2005). Every character appears on screen for the first time in this universe.

- **This is the first shared cinematic universe in film history.** No studio has tried anything like it. The industry has no word for it yet, and the fans will have to invent one.
 - **What this means for Thanos:** Galactus, the Silver Surfer, Mephisto, Adam Warlock, Doctor Doom, the mutants and the Fantastic Four are all available at full comic power for the Infinity Saga. **Nobody is left out, and nobody is nerfed.**
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1B. CONTINUITY: EARTH-616 (LOCKED)

The whole universe is adapted from **Earth-616**, the main Marvel Comics continuity. Earth-1610 (Ultimate), movie-only versions and "reimagined" origins are not allowed. Where the 616 comics have updated a detail over time (Marvel's sliding timescale), we use the latest 616 version.

Earth-616 anchors:

| Character | 616 canon we follow |

|---|---|

| **Nick Fury** | Jack Kirby's Fury: WWII sergeant of the **Howling Commandos**, lost his eye to a grenade and later became Director of **S.H.I.E.L.D. (Strategic Hazard Intervention Espionage Logistics Directorate**, the current 616 name since 1991. It was originally *Supreme Headquarters, International Espionage, Law-enforcement Division*.) The **Infinity Formula** keeps him in his fifties. **Cast: Samuel L. Jackson (b. Dec 21, 1948), the one casting exception in the whole saga.** His history, powers and personality are 100% 616. |

| **Iron Man** | Tony Stark, captured by insurgents and builds the Mark I with **Ho Yinsen**. The war is Afghanistan (the sliding-timescale update in *Extremis*, 2005). **Obadiah Stane is Iron Monger**, and the **Mandarin** and his ten rings of alien origin are part of Tony's world. |

| **The Hulk** | Bruce Banner is caught in the blast of the **gamma bomb** while saving **Rick Jones**. The madder Hulk gets, the stronger Hulk gets, **with no upper limit**. Hulk is part of the Avengers from day one. |

| **Thor** | The Odinson, sent to Earth by Odin to learn humility, first living as the mortal **Dr. Donald Blake**. **Mjolnir** is enchanted with "Whosoever holds this hammer, if he be worthy..." |

| **Captain America** | Steve Rogers, Project: Rebirth, **Dr. Abraham Erskine**, with **Bucky Barnes** at his side. He is lost at the end of the war and **frozen in ice until the Avengers find him**. |

| **The Avengers** | The founding line-up from *Avengers* #1 (1963): **Iron Man, Thor, the Hulk, Ant-Man (Hank Pym) and the Wasp (Janet van Dyne)**. They form to fight **Loki**. Cap is thawed out later and joins. |

| **Mutants** | Born with the X-gene. **Charles Xavier and Magneto (Max Eisenhardt)** are there from the start. |

| **Thanos** | Jim Starlin's 616 Thanos (see Section 7). |

2. THE ARCHITECT: KEVIN FEIGE

Title	President of Production, Marvel Studios (named March 2007). Becomes President of Marvel Studios later in 2007.
Born	June 2, 1973, Boston, MA (Westfield, NJ upbringing)
Age on Day One of our story (March 12, 2007)	33
Unofficial title	Keeper of the Codex: the one person with final say on continuity

Why Feige: he started as Lauren Shuler Donner's assistant on *Volcano* (1997) and *You've Got Mail* (1998). He joined Marvel Studios in 2000, when it had no films and no plans to make any. For seven years he has been developing all of them on paper. He's the only executive in town who reads the comics as primary source material instead of treating them as IP. He is patient, low-ego and always wears a baseball cap. He also has the one trait this plan depends on: **he can keep a secret for five years.**

Chain of command (2007):

- **David Maisel**, Chairman, Marvel Studios (financing architect)
 - **Kevin Feige**, President of Production (creative and continuity)
 - **Avi Arad**, founder, **exits May 31, 2007**
 - Reports up to **Marvel Entertainment**, CEO **Ike Perlmutter**
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3. DISTRIBUTOR & ACQUIRER

Distributor: PARAMOUNT PICTURES

- 2005 deal: Paramount distributes and markets for a flat fee (about 8%). **Marvel keeps ownership, final cut and the sequel rights.**
- Paramount is hungry, reorganizing under Brad Grey, and doesn't ask for creative control. It's the ideal partner for a studio with a secret.
- **Covers:** Phase 1 through 2011.
- **Covers every Phase 1 film, *The Incredible Hulk* included.** Marvel has never licensed a character to another studio, so no outside studio holds a claim on any film.

Acquirer: THE WALT DISNEY COMPANY

- **Monday, August 31, 2009:** Disney announces it is acquiring Marvel Entertainment for **about \$4.0 billion** in cash and stock. CEO **Bob Iger** (b. Feb 10, 1951, age 58) closes the deal on December 31, 2009.

- Disney buys Paramount's distribution rights to **The Avengers (2012)**. **Walt Disney Studios Motion Pictures** distributes everything from Phase 2 on.
- **Deal term (canon):** Marvel Studios keeps full creative autonomy. Feige keeps final say on story and continuity. Disney handles marketing, parks, merchandise and international reach.

Why Disney: it has the global reach to make a 29-film saga an event without absorbing it into the Disney brand. It's the only buyer with both the money and the patience for a ten-year plan.

4. STRUCTURE: SERIALIZED vs. STANDALONE

The target: 60% SERIALIZED / 40% STANDALONE

It ramps up by phase, so audiences are gradually trained to expect connection:

Phase	Years	Films	Serialized	Standalone
Phase 1	2008–2012	8	35%	65%
Phase 2	2013–2015	9	60%	40%
Phase 3	2016–2019	12	80%	20%
Saga total	2008–2019	29	≈61%	≈39%

THE FIVE LAWS OF THE CODEX (continuity)

1. **Every film is somebody's first film.** It has to work completely on its own, and the connective tissue is a bonus.
 2. **Real-time rule.** Each film takes place in the year it's released unless it's explicitly set in the past. Characters age on their real birthdays.
 3. **Scars stay.** Injuries, losses, trauma and tech upgrades carry forward and are logged.
 4. **Death is permanent** unless the comics give an explicit, established mechanism for a return.
 5. **Nobody gets nerfed.** Every hero and villain shows up at comic-accurate power levels. When a character loses, it's because of story, strategy or a mismatch. It's never because the character was written down to make someone else look good.
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5. GENRE, RATING, RUNTIME

Core genre: superhero action-adventure.

House rule: every film **wears a second genre**, so no two installments play the same.

Hero	Subgenre
Iron Man	Techno-thriller / military-industrial drama
The Hulk	Fugitive thriller / monster movie
Thor	Shakespearean mythological epic
Captain America	WWII war epic, then a 1970s paranoid-conspiracy thriller
The Avengers	Ensemble war film / disaster epic
Black Panther	Royal succession drama / espionage
Doctor Strange	Occult horror-fantasy
Ant-Man	Heist caper
Guardians / Cosmic	Space opera

Rating: Hard PG-13 is the default. Stakes are real, violence has consequences, and there's blood when the story calls for it. Street-level characters (Blade, Punisher, Daredevil, Moon Knight) are held for a future **R-rated** label so they never have to be watered down.

Runtime (long but reasonable):

- Solo origins: **140–160 min**
- Sequels / team-ups: **155–175 min**
- Phase-ending crossovers: **180–200 min**
- **Hard ceiling: 3 hr 20 min**

6. PRODUCTION DOCTRINE

- **Actors do their own stunts and motion capture.** Stunt teams train with them, rig them and keep them safe. They don't replace them.
- **100% practical first.** Real suits, real sets, real explosions, real locations. CGI and VFX are used only where physics or safety require it, such as cosmic realms, the Hulk and Thanos, and they're built on top of practical references and on-set mo-cap.
- **Shoot on location first.** Soundstages are only for what can't exist in the real world.

7. THE BIG BAD: THANOS, THE MAD TITAN

First appearance: *Iron Man* #55 (Feb. 1973), created by **Jim Starlin** (with Mike Friedrich).

Comic-accurate canon (LOCKED)

- **Origin:** an **Eternal of Titan**, son of **A'Lars (Mentor)** and **Sui-San**, brother of **Eros (Starfox)**. He was born with the **Deviant Syndrome**, which gives him his gray, ridged look.
- **Motivation:** he is **in love with Mistress Death**. He kills half of all life as a **courtship offering** to win her. **It is not about resources or overpopulation**. Death is a character in this saga, and she never speaks to him.
- **Power level (no nerfs):** before he ever touches a Gem, Thanos can trade blows with the Hulk and Thor, knows cosmic science beyond Tony Stark, and is a master strategist. With the **Infinity Gauntlet** he is **omnipotent**. The heroes lose because the Gauntlet is literally godhood, not because they're weak.
- **The six Infinity Gems** (called "**Gems**" on screen, never "Stones"): **Soul, Mind, Power, Space, Time, Reality**. The Soul Gem is tied to **Adam Warlock**.
- **Comic colors (locked):** Soul **green** · Mind **blue** · Power **red** · Space **purple** · Time **orange** · Reality **yellow**.
- **Origin:** first called "**Soul Gems**" (the Soul Gem debuted in *Marvel Premiere* #1, 1972). They were named the **Infinity Gems** in *Silver Surfer Annual* #2 and *The Thanos Quest* (1990). They are the remains of a single being that existed before the universe and chose to shatter itself.
- **The Gauntlet:** Thanos's **Infinity Gauntlet** is a plain gold glove with no special properties of its own. All the power comes from the Gems.
- **His people:** **Gamora** (adopted daughter, "the deadliest woman in the galaxy"), **Nebula** (his self-proclaimed granddaughter), and **the Black Order**.
- **The fatal flaw** (Starlin's thesis, spoken by Adam Warlock): "*Deep down, Thanos believes he doesn't deserve to win. He always leaves himself a way to lose.*"
- **Endgame players, all comic-accurate:** Adam Warlock, the Silver Surfer, Mephisto, Nebula, and cosmic entities at full power.

THE SAGA NAME: THE INFINITY SAGA

Taken directly from Starlin's run, *The Thanos Quest* → *The Infinity Gauntlet* → *The Infinity War*. It isn't the name of a franchise, so it can be said out loud. It's the name of a story, and the public won't learn it until the right moment.

Seeding plan:

- **Phase 1 (locked in the dossiers):**
- **Mistress Death** appears unexplained at Yinsen's death (*Iron Man*) and turns away from Bucky (*Captain America*).
- **Titan** is detected three times (*Iron Man*, *Hulk*, *Thor*).
- Thanos's face is **glimpsed** twice (*Ant-Man and the Wasp*, *Captain America*).
- The **first mention of the Infinity Gems** comes from the Mandarin (*Iron Man 2*).
- The **Cosmic Cube**, Thanos's first target on 616, is built by A.I.M. (*Captain America*).
- Xavier senses **a mind smiling at Earth** (*X-Men*).
- **Final shot of Phase 1** (*The Avengers*): a purple hand, a golden glove with six empty settings, Death at his side, and one line: "*...is to court Death.*"

- *The Gems stay off Earth in Phase 1. On 616 they're scattered across the cosmos among the Elders of the Universe until The Thanos Quest.*

- **Phase 2: The Thanos Quest.** He starts collecting.

- **Phase 3 (locked in the dossiers):** *Civil War* breaks the heroes apart; Mephisto convinces Thanos to take "half of everything"; **the snap** (*Avengers: The Infinity Gauntlet*, 2018); **five lost years**; **Warlock** comes out of the Soul Gem; **Cap's last stand** and **Warlock's reversal** (*Avengers Forever*, 2019). **Thanos becomes a farmer. Death never chooses him.** The saga ends with *The Amazing Spider-Man 2*.

8. THE SECRET

- **No one outside Project Bullpen hears the word "universe."** Actor contracts carry **multi-picture options** described as "sequel protection."
 - Post-credit scenes are shot with **skeleton crews** under **fake slate names**, and the pages are handed out on set and collected afterward.
 - **The franchise has no name.** The press and fans will name it. Feige's standing order: "*When they name it, we'll know we've won.*"
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9. THE PREMIER TEAM: THE AVENGERS

"Earth's Mightiest Heroes"

Why the Avengers: the Avengers are Marvel's flagship team, a group of heroes who each carry their own book and come together against threats no single hero can handle. That's the whole MCU model in one team. Every solo film builds toward them, and against Thanos in *The Infinity Gauntlet* they're Earth's front line. The Fantastic Four are Marvel's first family and the X-Men are their own world, and both are available to us, but only the Avengers are *built* out of other heroes' franchises.

THE FOUNDING ROSTER (*The Avengers* #1, Sept. 1963, Stan Lee & Jack Kirby)

Founder	Played by	616 role on the team
Iron Man (Tony Stark)	Marc-Anthony Bullock	Bankroller. He gives the team his Manhattan mansion and pays for everything.
Thor	Esther Smiley	The team's powerhouse and a literal god
The Hulk (Bruce Banner)	Amond Baker	The strongest one there is, and the team's biggest risk
Ant-Man (Dr. Hank Pym)	Tyler Chapman	Scientist and founder. He becomes Giant-Man in <i>Avengers</i> #2.
The Wasp (Janet van Dyne)	Elxa Bullock	She names the team. In #1 she suggests calling them "the Avengers."

How they form (616-accurate): **Loki**, in exile, plans revenge on Thor. He makes the Hulk look like a rampaging menace. **Rick Jones** sends a radio call to the Fantastic Four for help, but Loki redirects it to Thor. Iron Man, Ant-Man and the Wasp pick up the signal too. The five heroes realize they were manipulated, beat Loki together, and decide to stay together.

THE 616 WAVES THAT FOLLOW (so nobody is left out)

Wave	Comic	Who joins	Played by
The Sentinel of Liberty	<i>Avengers</i> #4 (1964)	Captain America. The Avengers find him frozen in the ice and thaw him out. He becomes the team's leader.	Tyrese Avery
"Cap's Kooky Quartet"	<i>Avengers</i> #16 (1965)	Hawkeye, the Scarlet Witch, and Quicksilver. Hawkeye and the twins all start out as villains before they reform.	Arianna Cummings (Claire Barton), Grace Bullock (Wanda), Quicksilver cast from real actors (showrunner's pick)
The Widow	<i>Avengers</i> #111 (1973)	Black Widow. She starts as a Soviet spy against Iron Man (<i>Tales of Suspense</i> #52), becomes Hawkeye's partner, and defects.	Harmony Divine

616 details we keep:

- The team's headquarters is **Avengers Mansion**, Tony's family home at 890 Fifth Avenue.
- **Edwin Jarvis** is the team's human butler and the heart of the Mansion.
- The rallying cry is "**Avengers Assemble!**"
- The **Avengers charter** and a government liaison connect the team to S.H.I.E.L.D.
- Line-ups keep changing, as they always have in the comics. The founders leave and come back.